

Code of the Pyramids

Full run-book for the team. What each person does, minute by minute, with scripted lines. It contains the answers and the lock code.

4 hours

on the plateau

30

guests, 6 teams

3 flows

of 10 guests

10

staff on duty

Only what stands in front of you can be counted

Guests are given an archaeologist's field diary. It holds twelve pages: six genuine and six rewritten by someone who never stood on the plateau. At six stops the teams check what is written against what they can see. Four observations produce a number, two do not. The numbers open the lock.

THE ANSWERS. NEVER SAID ALOUD BEFORE THE CLOSING SESSION

Lock code: 2 – 2 – 3 – 4. The numbers are ordered from smallest to largest.

How the forgery shows: genuine pages name compass directions, "the north face", "by the east face". The forged ones say "to the right of the entrance", "on the left along the road". Someone who was never there describes a picture, not a place.

Second tell: genuine pages never state a number. Forged ones always do, and always wrongly.

Who rewrote it: the courier who hands the group the lock box in the morning and stays with them all day. He does not want the box. He wants a sheet of paper signed by thirty people that certifies his version of the route.

2 • WHO WORKS THE SHIFT

WHO	WHOSE	WHAT THEY DO
Lead host	ours	Runs the day. Prologue, rules, stop-change signals, closing session, the lock, the awards. Senior on the route.
Assistants, 3	ours	One per two teams. Read the task, keep time, take the bets, hand out envelopes, apply the stamps, take photographs.
Coordinator	ours	Coach, water, toilets, closing venue, printing on the move. He also plays the courier.
Guides, 3	partner	One per flow. They carry the history. They explain only after the team has bet.
Site coordinator	partner	Tickets, entry, coach standing points, liaison with the plateau administration.

Actors are optional. In the base version the coordinator plays the courier. He acts nothing out, he simply delivers two written lines. A hired actor buys presentation, not the plot.

One list of duties each

LEAD HOST

1. On the coach: roll call, six folders, roles, rules, prologue. Scripts on page 5.
2. Takes the lock box from the courier in front of the guests and puts it on the front seat, in plain sight. The box stays visible all day.
3. At the gate she decides whether flows go in order or in a circle. She tells the guides in one radio sentence.
4. At each stop she gives the start signal and the change signal. She watches the grid, not her feeling of time.
5. Once during the day she delivers the planned false statement at the Sphinx. Details on page 10.
6. Runs the whole closing session: the strips, the argument with the courier, the code, the letter, the awards.
7. Carries the case: duplicates of every document, a spare shackle and the lock key.

ASSISTANT, EACH RUNS TWO TEAMS

1. Arrives at the stop ahead of his teams and finds where two groups of five can stand without blocking the path.
2. Reads the task for the stop word for word. The text is short and is never paraphrased.
3. Calls the time aloud: "five minutes", "two minutes". The team must hear how long is left.
4. Takes the bet: tokens go on the corner of the sheet, all together, in one movement. After the bet nothing is recounted.
5. Only now does he let them open the check envelope.
6. Stamps the evidence sheet. He certifies what the team saw with their own eyes, even when the number is wrong.
7. Photographs the team at the stop. The picture goes onto the sheet printed on the coach.

COORDINATOR, ALSO THE COURIER

1. Before departure: water, first aid kit, charged radio guides, props packed by case.
2. In the morning he hands the host the box and the diaries in front of the guests and reads the note. Script on page 5.
3. He stays near the group all day and explains nothing. To questions he answers: "I am carrying out an instruction."
4. During the fourth block he drives ahead and sets up the closing area: tables, the chart on the wall, the box on the centre table.
5. On the coach he prints six route sheets with the team photographs.
6. In the closing session he enters with the envelope at minute 13 and delivers his lines. He adds nothing.

PARTNER GUIDE

1. Leads his flow of ten all day and answers questions on the history.
2. Stays silent while the team observes and argues. This is the hardest rule and the most important one.
3. Gives the full explanation only after the team has placed its tokens and opened the envelope.

Three checks that are never skipped

WHEN	WHAT WE DO	WHO
The day before, daytime	Briefing for the partner guides: one hour in a room, one hour walking the route. Each guide receives the station pack and walks his own stops.	Host
The day before, evening	Packing: six folders assembled and numbered. Check that every folder holds all its envelopes and its rule strip.	Assistants
The day before, evening	The lock: enter 2-2-3-4 and open it three times in a row. Spare shackle and key into the case.	Host
3 hours before	Radio guides charged and tested on every channel. Water loaded: 1.5 litres per guest plus reserve.	Coordinator
45 minutes before	Staff on site. The host hands out radios, states the order of stops and confirms which guide leads which flow.	Everyone

WE DO NOT DEPART WITHOUT THESE

- The reconnaissance is done and the four code numbers are confirmed on site.
- Materials are printed against the confirmed numbers, not last time's.
- The photographs in the check envelopes were taken from the exact spots the teams will stand on.
- The closing venue is confirmed in writing: six tables, a centre table, space for the chart.
- The expedition letter is printed with the client's company name in it.

5 • DIVIDING THE GROUP

Teams are composed in advance from the client's list, never on site. Six envelopes with names, five names in each. That way senior people end up in different teams and no five minutes are lost to "can I be with Olga".

ROLE	WHAT THEY HOLD	WHAT ONLY THEY MAY DO
Reader	The expedition diary	Reads the pages aloud, one per stop. Only they hold the diary.
Observer	The viewfinder card	Counts and says aloud what they see. The number enters the sheet in their voice.
Mapper	The plateau plan and compass	Determines the compass directions and leads the team along the path.
Checker	The sealed envelopes	Opens the envelope after the bet. Until then it lies seal upwards.
Speaker	The evidence sheet	Speaks to the assistant, announces the bet, turns a dial at the closing session.

Roles rotate one position after the second and after the fourth stop, and once more before the closing session. The host gives the signal.

The twenty minutes that set up the day

Before departure	Roll call. The coordinator hands out water. The assistants give out six folders, one into the hands of each team's keeper.
Minute 1	The courier hands the host the box and the diaries. In front of the guests, in silence, with a note.
Minutes 2-4	Roles. Each team assigns its five roles itself, aloud. Assistants help anyone who hesitates.
Minutes 5-7	The rules and the host's prologue.
THE HOST READS THE COURIER'S NOTE	«Delivered on instruction. The notebook and the box belong to Doctor Amir Kamal's expedition. A decision is requested before sunset.»
THE RULES, HOST, WORD FOR WORD	«We have five rules and all of them are short. One: we look from the ordinary visitor paths, and from there you can see exactly what we need today. Two: everything you may touch today is our own prop, made for that purpose. Three: before every check the team places its tokens on its version, all together, in one movement. Four: getting it wrong is allowed, going home without the ending is not, the box opens today no matter what. And five: once in these four hours one of us will tell you something untrue, and tell it confidently. The team that catches us gets a token. Agreed?»
THE PROLOGUE, HOST, WORD FOR WORD	«Friends, the notebook in your hands is the field diary of Doctor Amir Kamal. An hour ago a man handed it to us together with this box, and he is travelling with us all day. He says he is carrying out an instruction. Whose instruction, he does not say. There is a problem with the diary. In the spring Kamal noticed that pages he had not written had appeared in it. Someone was copying his observations and inserting their own. So Kamal did one thing: he took the real route out of the diary and turned it into six observations that can be counted here on the plateau. He wrote the numbers on the last page and locked it in this box. Four dials, and nobody knows the code, myself included. After that the expedition went silent. It is silent still. Four hours, six observations, six teams. Our witnesses are the best available: they have stood here for four and a half thousand years and have never lied to anyone. Open the diary at the first page. There are two of them, and they describe the same thing. Which one was written by someone who actually stood here?»

WHAT ASSISTANTS KEEP TO THEMSELVES ALL DAY

Two of the six stops produce no number. The teams must discover this only at the closing session. Not a word, not a hint, not a change of tone. The stamp goes into the sheet identically at all six stops.

Two different jobs

Where	The area by the north face, away from the queue for the inner passage. The three flows line up along the face 30 to 50 metres apart, facing the pyramid.
Props per team	Diary, pages 1 and 1-bis. Viewfinder card. Evidence sheet. Pencil. Six tokens. A sealed envelope with a photograph of the north face with two openings circled. The assistant carries the ENTRANCES stamp.
ASSISTANT, WORD FOR WORD	«Friends, the diary says there is one opening in this face and that the builders made it. Observer, look at the face and say out loud how many openings you can see.»
0-2	The assistant reads the task. The reader reads both diary pages aloud, the genuine one and the forged one.
2-6	The observer scans the face through the viewfinder window and says the number of openings aloud, with no explanation. The others count after them.
6-10	The team describes the edges of each opening. One is framed by even stonework, the other is a ragged breach with rubble below it.
10-12	The conclusion: an even frame costs a builder weeks, and someone searching for another man's treasure spends nothing on it. So the two openings were made by different people at different times.
12-13	The bet. The speaker announces it, the tokens go on the corner of the sheet. They bet on the number and on which opening is older.
13-15	The check. The checker opens the envelope and the team compares the photograph with the face themselves.
15-18	The guide. The upper opening with the even frame is the ancient entrance. The lower breach is associated with Caliph al-Ma'mun's ninth-century works, when the inner chambers were being searched for. That is where the difference in edges comes from.
18-20	The assistant asks: "Who counted, and how many times?" and stamps the line.

THE ANSWER

There are two openings. The older is the upper one with the even frame. The genuine diary page is the one that calls the face the north face. **Into the sheet: ENTRANCES – 2.**

Hint 1. "Count first, explain afterwards." **Hint 2.** "Look at the edges. Which of the two was in a hurry?"

If the second opening reads badly from the permitted spot, the stop moves to the remains of casing at the base of the face: how many courses survive. That changes the number, and with it the lock code and the rule strips, so the decision is taken at the reconnaissance and never on the day.

Where the photographer stood

Where The official panorama point with the view of the three pyramids, and the permitted stretch of path beside it. It is a busy spot: the assistant immediately takes his two teams 40 to 50 metres away from the vendors and the camels.

Props Diary, pages 3 and 3-bis. A 15 by 20 cm print of the panorama. A plan with six numbered points. Viewfinder. A sealed note with the heights. Sheet, tokens. The PANORAMA stamp.

ASSISTANT, WORD FOR WORD

«Friends, the diary holds a photograph of this panorama with a caption: taken from here, and from here you can see that the middle pyramid is the tallest. Mapper, find the spot the photograph was taken from. In the meantime we shall believe the caption.»

0-3 The task and both pages. The team compares the view with the photograph: the summits line up differently.

3-5 A first vote by eye: which pyramid looks taller? The assistant writes the answer in pencil and says nothing. Almost every team names the middle one.

5-14 The mapper walks the team along the path through the six marked points. At each one the observer uses the viewfinder to compare the relative position of the three summits with the photograph.

14-16 The team names the point where the photograph matches and puts into words what its author did: he invented nothing, he chose where to stand.

16-17 **The bet** on the number of the point.

17-20 **The check.** The checker opens the note with the heights and base levels and the team reads it aloud.

20-23 **The guide.** Khufu is the taller structure, 146.6 metres against 143.5, but it stands lower. Khafre's base sits on bedrock about ten metres higher, its faces are steeper and casing survives at the top. So its apex really is higher above sea level and it looks bigger from almost anywhere on the plateau.

23-25 The assistant stamps the line and takes the team photograph against the panorama.

THE ANSWER

An impression does not measure height. Khufu is the taller structure, Khafre's apex is higher above sea level, and those are two different statements. **Into the sheet: IMPRESSION IS NOT MEASUREMENT.** This stop yields no number, and at the closing session that turns out to matter.

Hint 1. "Walk twenty paces along the path and look at the summits again." **Hint 2.** "Look at the height each pyramid starts from."

For a corporate group this is the most discussed idea of the day, and it is about reports and presentations rather than pyramids. First-class deception is not invention, it is a chosen point of view. The guide may say so aloud.

The key that is not in the folder

Where The viewpoint by Khafre from which both Khafre and the east face of Khufu with the subsidiary pyramids at its foot are visible.

Props Diary, pages 2 and 2-bis. A paper seal of eight signs. Three cut-out stencils. Compass. Viewfinder. A sealed note about the ruler's names. Sheet, tokens. The SUBSIDIARIES stamp.

ASSISTANT, WORD FOR WORD

«Friends, the diary holds a seal of eight signs and a note: I did not write the key down, it stands in front of you and has not changed in four thousand years. Reader, read the note again and tell us where to look for the key.»

0-2	The task. The team discovers that the key is not in the folder.
2-6	The observer finds the row of small pyramids at the foot of the great one and counts them aloud. The forged page states one more than there are, so they count twice.
6-11	The key. Three stencils cover part of the seal, and a readable word appears in only one order of overlay: the order in which the three main pyramids stand from north to south. The mapper works it out with the compass.
11-12	The team reads the seal: four signs stay uncovered and spell the name KHUFU.
12-13	The bet on the number of small pyramids and on the name read from the seal.
13-16	The check. The note says: Khufu is the king's Egyptian name, Cheops the Greek rendering of it. Two documents, one name, one man. For the rest of the day we say only Khufu.
16-18	The guide. The small pyramids by the east face are queens' tombs, part of the same design as the great one. They were treated as surplus as late as the nineteenth century, when plateau plans were drawn from memory.
18-20	The assistant stamps the line.

THE NUMBER THE WHOLE DAY DEPENDS ON

How many small pyramids can be counted with confidence from this exact spot is confirmed at the reconnaissance. **This number goes into the lock code.** If a different count is visible on site, the code and all six rule strips change. Nothing here may be changed on the day.

THE ANSWER

There are three small pyramids. The stencil order runs north to south. The seal reads KHUFU. **Into the sheet: SUBSIDIARIES – 3.**

Hint 1. "Your key is not in the folder. It is in front of you." **Hint 2.** "Place the shapes in the order the three pyramids stand in from north to south, and read the seal again."

The flows swap over on the host's signal

The two stops run at the same time: one at the valley temple, the other on the terrace in front of the Sphinx. After fourteen minutes the host gives the signal and the flows swap over.

STOP 4. WHERE THE ROAD LEADS

ASSISTANT «Friends, these are the real stones of that road, and in the diary its sequence has been rewritten with extra links added. Observer, where is the low ground here, where is the high ground, and where does the road go?»

0-2 The task and both pages.

2-6 The observer and the mapper work out the relief and the direction: where the water was closer, where the climb begins, where it leads.

6-9 The team lays out only the cards that form an unbroken road. Two cards are surplus and they are plausible: such buildings existed in the complexes, but they are not part of the road from the water to the pyramid.

9-10 **The bet** on the number of links.

10-12 **The check** and the discussion.

12-14 **The guide.** Valley temple, causeway, mortuary temple, pyramid. East to west, from the water into the desert. The pharaoh's road repeats the road of the sun.

The answer. Four links. East to west. **Into the sheet: LINKS – 4.** Hints: "Start with the link you could have sailed to" and "Two cards describe buildings the living need, not the dead."

STOP 5. WHAT IS VISIBLE AND WHAT IS KNOWN

ASSISTANT «Friends, the diary makes three claims about this witness. Checker, read them aloud and tell us which of the three we can verify from here, with our own eyes.»

Three claims, all plausible. A: the face can be identified by appearance. B: the number of creatures combined in the figure can be established by appearance. C: the date it was carved can be established by appearance.

The team tests each claim by its own observation against a checklist. A human head and a lion's body are distinguishable from the terrace, so B is verifiable. Whose face it is and when it was carved cannot be established from here. They bet on the letter and on the number of creatures, then the check, then the guide: the combined figure is a sign of royal power rather than a portrait of an animal; the stela between the paws was set up by Thutmose the Fourth roughly a thousand years after the Sphinx itself.

The answer. B is correct. Two creatures. **Into the sheet: CREATURES – 2.**

THIS IS WHERE THE DAY'S ONE PLANNED UNTRUTH BELONGS

As the flow approaches the terrace the guide says confidently: "The Sphinx was built up out of blocks, like a pyramid." The genuine diary page states that the guardian was cut from a single rock and that this is visible in the layers. The team that catches the contradiction gets a token and an award. If nobody has caught it within three minutes, the guide repeats the sentence, louder.

A report on a place you never visited

This stop runs on the transfer to the closing venue, after the toilets and the water. Teams sit together with folders on their laps. The reading lights must work: the guests read a text.

HOST, AFTER THE
COURIER HANDS OVER
THE ENVELOPE AT THE
STANDING POINT

«This was delivered five minutes ago. A report on the third pyramid, the one we did not approach today. They are asking for a decision before the closing session. Friends, you have fifteen minutes: can this report be accepted?»

0-2	The assistants hand out the reports and the sealed rule strips, saying: "We do not read this until the room."
2-9	The team works through the report with the method of the day: what does each statement rest on, something counted, something measured, or an impression. The reader underlines everything that could be counted.
9-11	They choose: accept, reject, or cannot be verified from here. The bet.
11-13	The assistant collects the decision sheets. There is no check envelope here: the check arrives at the closing session, in the expedition's letter.
13-15	The assistant stamps the line DECISION. What is certified is the act of deciding, whichever of the three it was.

THE ANSWER

"It cannot be verified from here" is the best answer, and it takes full marks and an award of its own. A team that writes beside it how it could be verified gets an extra token. **Into the sheet: CANNOT BE VERIFIED.** This stop yields no number.

Hint 1. "Underline everything in the report that can be counted. How many underlinings did you get?"

Hint 2. "Four times today you refused to believe a well-written page. This is the fifth."

For a corporate group this is the most valuable minute of the programme: "I do not know" is a professional answer, not a weakness. It also explains the closing rule, so this stop is never shortened. If the drive is under fifteen minutes, the stop moves to the first minutes in the room, before seating.

The lock remembers only what can be counted

Six tables, one per team, a centre table for the box, and on the wall a large plateau chart with six empty windows. Nobody is given the code. The reading rule is cut into six strips, one per team, and can only be assembled together.

00-06	Seating, water. Each team pins its six certified findings into its window on the chart. It is immediately visible that somebody's numbers differ from their neighbours'. The host does not comment.
06-13	The host puts the box on the centre table: "Six findings, four dials. The reading rule was on the last page of the diary, and he tore it out and then cut it up." The teams open their strips and lay them on the centre table. Assembled, the rule reads: "The lock remembers only what can be counted. From smallest to largest."
13-21	The courier enters with an envelope. He brings a ready-made code, 1-3-4-5, and his own version of the route sheet for the speakers to sign. The host stays out of the argument until minute 19. By minute 21 the teams state which numbers they counted themselves, and the tell in the handwriting: compass directions against "right" and "left".
21-28	Sorting. Countable: 2, 2, 3, 4. Uncountable: "impression is not measurement" and "cannot be verified", precisely the two stops where the team learned not to trust. In ascending order: 2-2-3-4. The two identical twos always start an argument. Do not shut it down.
28-35	Entering the code. By lot, four teams each turn one dial and the remaining two come to the box and say aloud what did not go into the code and why. If even one number is wrong the shackle stays shut and for two minutes the whole group compares sheets between tables. This is the best team moment of the day.
35-43	The host takes the diary's last page and the expedition's letter out of the box and reads the letter aloud. Under the letter lie thirty fragments of the sun seal, one for each guest. The coordinator hands out the six route sheets printed on the way.
43-50	Awards without scores, and a group photograph at the open box: six hands on four dials with Khufu behind them.

THE HOST BEFORE THE OPENING, WORD FOR WORD

«Friends, four times today you were offered a well-written page to believe, and once a ready-made code. Instead you counted for yourselves. Four numbers, four dials, six teams. Who turns first?»

THE SAFETY CATCH

If the shackle does not release, the host says: "One number is wrong. Two minutes, compare your sheets between tables, out loud." After two minutes, however it has gone, she enters the correct code herself with the words "So that is the number he left for me" and opens the box. All six teams get the ending whatever happens.

If a rule strip is lost: the host carries a full duplicate. She lays the missing strip down in silence, without explanation, and carries on.

If the group signed the courier's sheet: nothing is replayed. The expedition's letter allows for exactly this, and the host reads it as written. The group's mistake becomes part of the ending.

The decisions are made in advance so nobody has to think on site

WHAT HAPPENED	WHAT WE DO
The queue at the gate is longer than usual	There are ten minutes of slack in the block. If that is not enough, cut the guide's talk at the second stop, never the closing session.
The stop is crowded	The flows go round in a circle. The host announces it in one radio sentence: "Circle, flow C starts at Khafre." The order does not affect the code.
Heat	The stop shrinks to observation, bet and check. The guide's talk moves into the shade at the next transfer.
A spot is closed off	The fallback agreed at the reconnaissance is used. It is never swapped quietly: if the number changes, the code changes.
A team cannot find the detail	The assistant counts aloud with the team and certifies the number as his own. At the closing session nobody can tell the difference.
A team counted wrongly	We do not correct it. The error travels to the closing session and the whole group hunts for it there. It is the best minute of the day.
More than 20 minutes behind	Drop one stop entirely rather than trimming all of them. The closing session keeps its full fifty minutes.
The box will not open	The safety catch, the spare shackle and the key are in the host's case.
A guest feels unwell	The coordinator takes them into the shade, water, first aid kit. The team continues: the roles are arranged so the five need not stand together.

14 • AFTER THE PROGRAMME

WHEN	WHAT	WHO
Straight away	Count the props against the list. The box, the stamps, the stencils and the chart leave with the coordinator. None of it goes to the guests.	
The same evening	The host writes one page: what ran over, where the teams argued, which wrong answer came up most often.	
The next day	To the client: photographs, a scan of the assembled sheet and a short report on how many teams reached the correct code.	
Within the week	Corrections to this run-book. Everything that had to be decided on site belongs here before the next group.	

ONE RULE MATTERS MORE THAN THE REST

The guest comes to see for themselves and count for themselves. Everything we do that day exists for the moment when they say: "Hold on, let us count that again." Any one of us who answers before that moment takes the whole day away from them.